

LAND OF THE RIFT

Africa

Africa is a gigantic continent; only Asia is larger. It stretches nearly 5,000 miles (8,000 km) from its most northerly point, Ras ben Sakka in Tunisia, to its most southerly point, Cape Agulhas in South Africa. It straddles the equator, which divides the continent in half, and consists of two large lobes—with the northern lobe extending far out west into the Atlantic Ocean, and the southern lobe running south between the Atlantic and Indian Oceans. The northern half is dominated by the world's largest desert—the Sahara. It is such an overwhelming geographical feature that Africa is often divided into the

Sahara and sub-Saharan Africa, the latter dominated by the western river basins filled with lush, tropical forests, and the drier, bushy grasslands or savanna on the eastern plateaus.

Despite its enormous size, Africa has no high mountain ranges, except for the Atlas in the extreme northwest. Much of the east and south are dominated by huge, high plateaus. In the northeast, the plateaus are split apart by the deep trench of the East African Rift valley, dotted by ribbons of huge lakes. The rift was created by tectonic forces beneath the crust cleaving the African Plate apart.

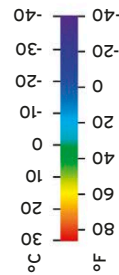
KEY DATA

▲ Highest point Mount Kilimanjaro, Tanzania: 19,341 ft (5,895 m)	● Hottest record Kebili, Tunisia: 131°F (55°C)
▼ Lowest point Lake Assal, Djibouti: -512 ft (-156 m)	● Coldest record Ifrane, Morocco: -11°F (-24°C)

CLIMATE

Most of Africa lies within the warm tropics. Except in the forest areas of the west, rainfall is scarce with just one wet season in the savanna and almost none in the Sahara.

AVERAGE TEMPERATURE



AVERAGE RAINFALL

